REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 05



Product / Project Translator

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what they need to decide. Give them a useful answer without promising work you cannot yet describe.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

START WITH A REAL SITUATION. DECIDE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

WORKING EDITION / REBEL-LEADER.COM

“Can you just give me the final requirements?”

You are still finding out what customers need. Someone needs a feature list, a date, or a budget. Both of you need an answer you can use. Start by asking what they need the answer for.

Find the decision behind the question

Finance may need to reserve money. Sales may need to tell a customer when to expect something. Another team may need to plan its work. Ask rather than guessing.

Say what you can answer now

If the work is understood and the team can give a reliable date, use it. If an important question is still open, explain exactly what it is.

Offer a useful next step

Perhaps you can agree to test two booking designs with customers in the next two weeks, then bring a build estimate to Finance. Name the work, the limit, and what they will be able to decide afterward.

Write a reply you would actually say

The Lab helps you check the request, prepare a commitment, and write the response. You do not need to teach someone product-management vocabulary before helping them plan.

> Try: “What do you need the feature list for? Which decision are you trying to make, and when do you need to make it?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

A request for final details can feel like somebody has misunderstood your job. They may simply be trying to do theirs. Find out what they need before correcting them.

What actually happened?

Write down what was said or done. Then notice what you have added. “They asked for Friday” and “They do not care about the team” are different statements. You can check the first. You need to ask about the second.

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? A customer could stop chasing an answer. Your team could finish the work it promised. Start there. Give the other person a chance to tell you what matters to them too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

Private notes in the Lab stay only in the open tab. They disappear when you refresh or leave and never appear in your exported documents. You can also think through these questions without typing.

> An opening you can adapt: “I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Ask what they will use the answer for.

Your first interpretation might be wrong. Give the person a chance to explain.

“We need final requirements”

“Which decision depends on that list? Do you need to reserve money, agree a contract, or get another team ready?” Find out which details need to be settled now.

“We need a firm date”

“Who is waiting for it, and what have they been told?” Ask the team for its current delivery estimate and what could change it.

“We need the full roadmap”

“How far ahead do you need to plan, and what will you use it for?” Explain which work is agreed, which is only a possibility, and when you will know more.

Record what they actually confirm

If you have not asked yet, write the question you will ask. Do not turn your guess about their motives into a fact in the reply.

> You are looking for an answer that helps them make their decision. Check that you understand it before writing the response.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What can we promise at this point?

Uncertainty does not have to leave the other person empty-handed. Be specific about what you can do and what they will learn from it.

Start with what you know

For example, customers currently phone to book repairs. There are two possible online designs. Neither has been tried with customers.

Name the question that matters

Can customers complete a booking using either design? How much work would the better one take to build? Say how you will find out.

Propose the work and its limits

Ask to spend up to $5,000 over two weeks to try both designs with five customers and get an Engineering estimate. Name who does each part. Those are fictional example amounts, not recommended defaults.

Explain what comes afterward

Bring the findings and estimate to Finance. Ask whether to fund the build, change the idea, or stop. Do not promise a finished service when you are only promising a customer test.

> A useful commitment says what you will do, who will do it, how much time or money you will use, and when the other person will hear back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Say it as you would in the meeting.

Start with what they need. Then explain what you can offer and ask for the decision you need.

Show that you heard them

“You need a spending limit by Thursday.” Use the need they confirmed, rather than an explanation you invented.

Make a concrete offer

“Could we set aside up to $5,000 for two weeks to try both booking designs with five customers and check the build work with Engineering?”

Explain what they will get back

“We will bring you the results, an estimate, and a recommendation before asking you to pay for the full build.”

Ask for a response

“Would that give you enough to make Thursday's decision?” Let them tell you if the offer does not meet their need. Revise it together.

> Read the message aloud. If you would not say a phrase in conversation, find the words you would use.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Keep working on the actual question.

Sometimes the first offer will not be enough. Ask what is missing.

“Just give me the date”

If the team has a reliable estimate for the agreed work, share it with its assumptions. Otherwise say what needs checking and when you can return with an estimate. Use Deadline Reset if a date has already been promised.

“We cannot approve an open-ended budget”

Agree a maximum spend and a stopping point. Explain what that money buys and what will still be unknown. The person paying can change or decline the proposal.

“We need to tell the customer something”

Work with the person responsible for that customer. State what is available, what is still being checked, and when the next update will come. Check any existing contractual promise.

“Why does the plan keep changing?”

Explain what you learned and how it changed the choice. If poor planning or communication also played a part, say so. Learning does not excuse keeping people in the dark.

> Try: “I want to give you something you can plan around. Which part of this still leaves you unable to make the decision?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Finance needs a budget by Thursday.

Fictional example: the finance director asks for the final feature list for an online repair-booking service. Customers have not tried either proposed design yet.

The product manager asks why

Finance needs a spending limit by Thursday. They do not need every screen agreed. The product manager checks that understanding before proposing a smaller first spend.

The proposed commitment

Propose spending up to $5,000 over two weeks to let five customers try both designs and ask Engineering what each would take to build. The product manager arranges the customer sessions; the engineering lead estimates the build work.

The reply

You need a budget by Thursday. Could we approve up to $5,000 for two weeks of customer testing first? Then we can show you which design works and what it would take to build before you commit to the full cost.

What happens next

In this example, Finance approves the limited spend on Thursday. The product manager books the customer sessions and the review two weeks later. Funding for the full build is still undecided. The Lab example starts before approval.

> Finance can plan the immediate spend. The team knows what to test. Nobody has pretended that the final design or full delivery date is already known.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Bring the sentence you heard.

You can prepare the reply before the conversation and update it after you have checked what the other person needs.

The request

Record their words, who asked, and what they need to decide. The starter buttons can help you begin; edit the wording to match your situation.

What they need

Choose the reason they need an answer, record what they confirmed, and name anything you still need to check. Build What They Need if you want to review your understanding.

What we can promise

Write what you know, what is still uncertain, and what you can offer now. Include the time, money, and other limits. Build Proposed Commitment.

Your reply

Write the short spoken version if useful, then the message. Name the decision you need and when. Build Your Reply as a proposal. Return after the conversation to record the answer and the next action.

> Load Examples shows the fictional booking-service case. Use your own facts before sharing a document.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Did anything actually change?

A completed form can look satisfying. The useful part is what people do with it.

Follow up

Bring the promised findings on the agreed date. Ask whether they helped the person make the decision. If you misunderstood the need or promised something too vague, revise the offer and check it with them.

Try saying it out loud

Read your proposed message to someone you trust. Ask where they got lost or what sounded strange. Could you say this to the person in a real meeting? Change anything you would have to translate as you spoke.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they do not follow you to another device. Private notes are not saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence does not mean yes.

> You do not have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you will check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic’s teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Two maps you can return to

Cultural Orbital Mechanics
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

How identity, relationships, and shared vision give rise to culture—and how that culture shapes people in return.

Holistic Impact Depth
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

Use the tree and five areas of health to look at what everyday work is doing to people.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 01

Find out what their words mean to them.

In Nic’s writing on shared language, a practical constraint can be a contribution to the idea. ‘Final requirements’ might mean Finance needs to know what funding would cover. Ask what decision the request serves before explaining your preferred way of working.

Worth asking: What do they need to decide, and what would help them decide it?

Stop Chasing Psychological Safety
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 02

Stay curious when the wording irritates you.

It is easy to hear a project word and prepare a lecture about Product. Notice the person using it. They have work, pressures, and responsibilities of their own. Nic’s bowl metaphor asks what kind of attention we bring to the relationship and whether we leave room to be changed by it.

Worth asking: What might you understand if you let them finish explaining the request?

Leadership as bowl, water, and current
Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Every leader needs contact lenses
Nic Payne · Substack Note

The Mirror Move
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

CHAPTER 04

Give uncertainty a useful next step.

You can make a real commitment without promising an answer you do not yet have. Say which question you will check, how, and by when. Teresa Torres's assumption-testing guide helps narrow that question. Nic's writing on certainty explains why a polished plan should not replace judgment.

Worth asking: Which belief must you check before asking people to commit to the whole build?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part II - The Seduction of Certainty
Nic Payne · Article

Assumption Testing: Everything You Need to Know to Get Started
Teresa Torres · Author's practical article

CHAPTER 05

Read your reply out loud.

"To lead differently, we must learn to speak a different language."

Nic Payne · The words we use for people

Nic's Note on the words we inherit asks us to notice when language hides the person. Name the customer waiting for a repair, the developer checking the change, and the colleague who needs a funding decision. If a sentence sounds like something nobody would say, rewrite it before sending.

Worth asking: Could the person receiving this explain what you are offering and what you need from them?

The words we use for people
Nic Payne · Substack Note

CHAPTER 06

Does your reply leave them able to participate?

Use HID to consider what repeated exchanges like this do to people. A correction can leave someone embarrassed and less willing to ask. A clear explanation can help both of you learn the work, make better judgments, and build trust. Be specific about what you can offer, and invite them to tell you what is still missing.

Worth asking: Can they question or change your proposal without being made to feel foolish?

Holistic Impact Depth
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

CHAPTER 09

Build a shared way to ask and answer.

After the immediate request, ask what you now understand about each other’s work. Keep the explanation and decision where the next person can find them. Cultural Orbital Mechanics helps trace how repeated encounters shape identity and relationship—and what becomes normal between teams.

Worth asking: Will the next request be easier because of what you learned together?

Cultural Orbital Mechanics
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

Do Your Replacement a Favor
Nic Payne · Article

Explore Nic’s articles, video, and the complete reading library.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.